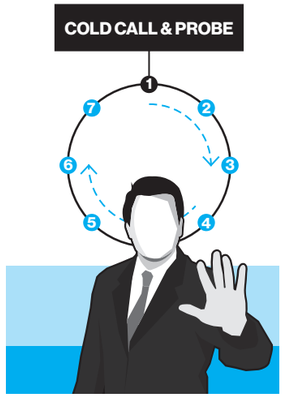
Teaching one Pagers

CHECKS FOR UNDERSTANDING

DESIGNING LESSONS WITH ONGOING RAPID FEEDBACK LOOPS

HOW DO I IMPLEMENT CfU CHECKS?

To make rapid feedback loops work, build them into the flow of your lesson as short, low-stakes checks rather than end-point tests. Plan where you'll pause to gather evidence, use inclusive formats so every student shows their thinking (mini-whiteboards, think–pair–share, cold call), and script a few key prompts in advance to go beyond *"Does that make sense?"*. Each check for understanding should be diagnostic: surface what's secure, what's shaky, and what's misunderstood. Then act on what you find immediately — reteach, clarify, or extend — so misconceptions are corrected quickly.





CARL HENDRICK

"You're not really checking to see what they know, you're checking to see what you need to do next as a teacher. It's not so much if they understand it — you want to find out what they've understood and that means you have to show me."

***How Learning Happens CfU* Webinar** 2025



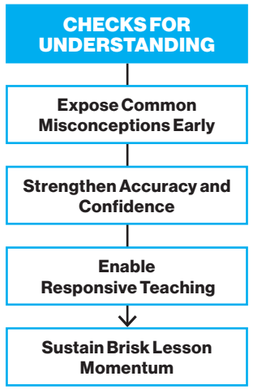
HAILI HUGHES

CfU is the most high-leverage thing a teacher can do... but it is only effective if it actually does what it says on the tin, which is diagnose understanding and leads to us making instructional adjustments.".

***How Learning Happens CfU* Webinar** 2025

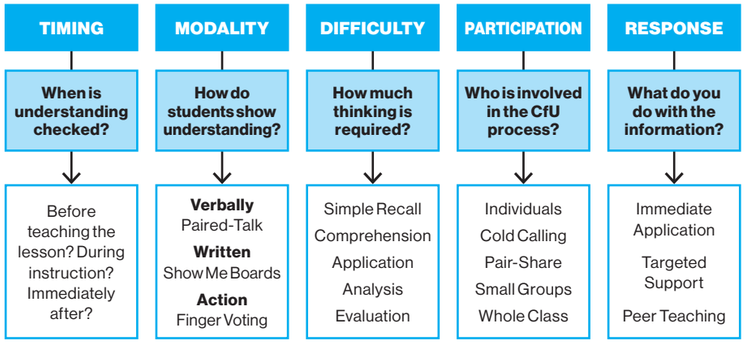
WHAT ARE CfU QUICK CHECKS?

Checking for understanding (CfU) is the heartbeat of effective teaching — a series of quick, low-stakes checks for student understanding built into the flow of a lesson to make thinking visible. Instead of waiting for marking cycles, use brief questions, mini-tasks or prompts to gather evidence in real time, then respond by adjusting instruction on the spot: reteaching, clarifying or extending before errors take hold. By sequencing these checks throughout the lesson — from baseline to self-assessment — feedback loops turn misconceptions into teachable moments and keep every learner moving towards mastery.



WHY ARE THESE QUICK CHECKS SO IMPORTANT?

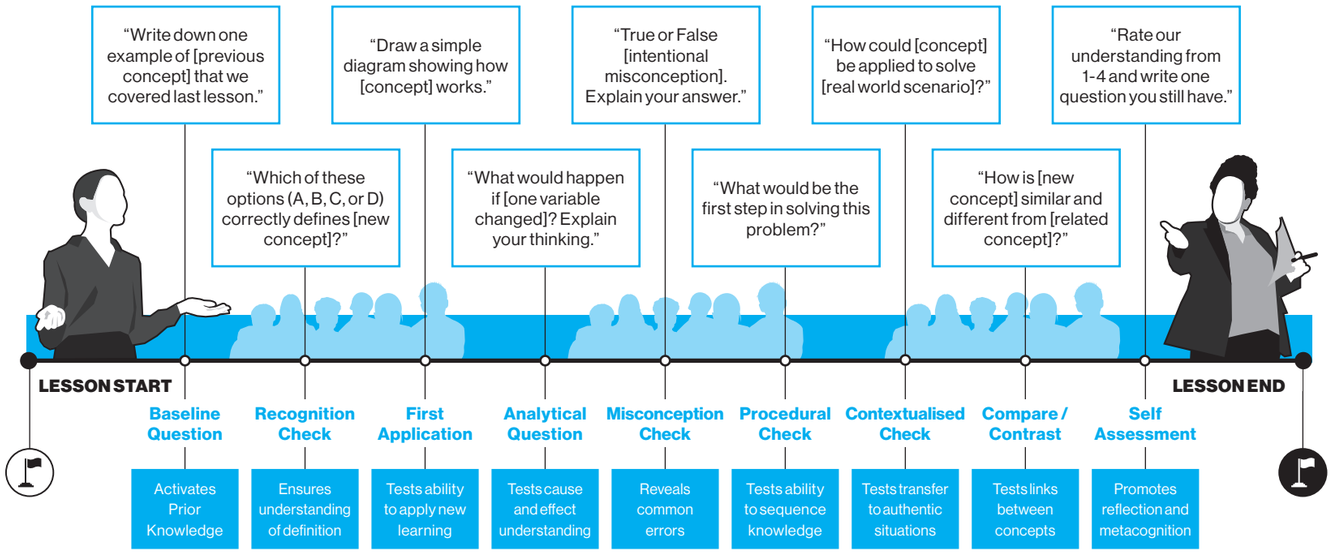
The visual below shows the five essential elements for CfU according to Carl Hendrick and Haili Hughes from their work on *How Learning Happens*. It maps out the key decisions teachers make — when to check, how to check, the level of difficulty, who participates, and what happens next . These rapid feedback loops prevent the illusion of learning: students can appear busy and engaged yet misunderstand key ideas, and these short checks expose gaps early. They also strengthen memory: answering questions, summarising steps, or applying ideas triggers retrieval and elaboration, embedding learning in long-term memory (Roediger & Karpicke, 2006). Finally, they enable responsive teaching: low-stakes feedback giving evidence on if to reteach or extend learning in real time.



CHOOSE THE FORMAT: Once you've planned when to check for understanding, the next decision is how. Will it be a quick whole-class response, a MWB task, a cold-call with wait-time, a paired explanation, or a short application task? Each format reveals something different — recall, reasoning, procedural clarity or misconceptions. Rotating between them stops CfU from becoming predictable, keeps students alert, and allows you to *see* thinking in multiple ways.

COLD CALL ONLY	As default, pose the question to everyone, give wait-time, then select who answers.
GO ON, SHOW ME	Use MWBs, finger voting etc to get an instant whole-class picture before moving on.
TEACH A PARTNER	Ask students to summarise, explain, or model a process to a partner in paired-talk.
DIG A BIT DEEPER	Ask "why?" or "how do you know?" to deepen thinking and expose reasoning.
THINK-PAIR-SHARE	Answer individually, discuss with a neighbour, then sample responses publicly.
REPEAT IT BACK	After giving instructions, call on students to restate the steps to ensure clarity.

SEQUENCING CfU ACROSS A LESSON: This diagram, developed by Carl Hendrick and Haili Hughes, shows how CfU can be deliberately sequenced across a lesson rather than left to chance. It maps a progression of low-stakes questions and tasks—from activating prior knowledge to self-assessment—that together make student thinking visible, reveal misconceptions early, and give teachers evidence to adapt instruction.



CC BY NC ND